

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART THREE · PEOPLE

CHAPTER 7 · CHARACTER

Who someone is, and whether a story is allowed to change them.

SUNSET BLVD.

Lost in Translation · 2003 · 102 min · written and directed by
Sofia Coppola · Focus Features

This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner.

*A father and a daughter, thirty-one years apart. Francis Ford Coppola's *The Godfather* follows a young man who swears he is nothing like his family and becomes the head of it, one of the biggest character transformations in film.*

*Sofia Coppola's *Lost in Translation* follows two strangers in a Tokyo hotel who barely change at all, and trusts that being truly seen is enough of a story. One is the full arc. The other is almost no arc.*

SUNSET BLVD.

LOST IN TRANSLATION

2003 · 102 min · written and directed by Sofia Coppola · Focus Features

A fading American movie star in Tokyo to shoot a whisky ad, and a young woman stuck in the same hotel while her husband works. Neither can sleep, and for one week they keep each other company.

Why it is on the ballot. Where *The Godfather* transforms its hero completely, this film barely moves its characters an inch, and that is the point. Nobody gets a big arc. They get noticed, by each other, and the film asks whether that small shift is enough to count as a story.

01

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

IT WAS WRITTEN FOR ONE ACTOR WHO NEVER SIGNED ANYTHING

Sofia Coppola wrote the part for Bill Murray, who at the time could only be reached through an 800-number answering service. She pursued him for months by phone and letter, flew to Tokyo and spent part of a \$4 million budget without knowing whether he would turn up. He turned up.

TWENTY-SEVEN DAYS

Principal photography began on 29 September 2002 and ran under a month, mostly in and around the Park Hyatt Tokyo.

SCARLETT JOHANSSON WAS SEVENTEEN

She played a recent college graduate while still a teenager. Coppola cast her without an audition.

02

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

THE FIRST RIDE IN

His face on a billboard

Bob arrives in Tokyo, jet-lagged, and passes an advertisement with his own face on it.

Why it matters: The film introduces its character as a stranger to himself. That is the whole arc, already there in the first minute.

THE WHISKY SHOOT

What got lost?

The director gives long, passionate instructions in Japanese. The translator gives Bob one short sentence.

Why it matters: It is the title, played as a joke. Most of what these characters feel never makes it across.

KARAOKE

“More Than This”

Bob sings the Roxy Music song to a room of new friends, and Charlotte watches him.

Why it matters: The most revealing moment in the film is a man half-singing a song badly. It trusts small things to carry big feelings.

THE LAST SCENE

The whisper

On a crowded street, one character whispers something to the other. You cannot hear it.

Why it matters: The film withholds the one line that would tell you what changed. The character moment belongs to them, not to you.

03

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

Nobody knows what he whispered

Murray improvised it, and Coppola chose not to dub it clear — it was meant to stay between the two of them. Fans have been trying to enhance the audio ever since.

OPEN

The songs

The closing track is “Just Like Honey” by The Jesus and Mary Chain, and Kevin Shields of My Bloody Valentine wrote original music for the film.

OPEN

One Oscar, from four nominations

It won Best Original Screenplay and was nominated for Best Picture, Best Director and Best Actor for Murray — a film with very little plot and some of the most famous silences of its decade.

- 01 Do Bob and Charlotte change? If they do not, why does the film still feel finished?
- 02 What do you think he whispered, and does it matter?
- 03 Michael Corleone transforms completely. These two barely move. Which felt more like a real person?

Where to watch

Find it here → [Lost in Translation on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: MovieMaker · the Academy’s awards database · CinemaBlend

THE LESSON

ONE JOURNEY, A THOUSAND FACES

A SCHOLAR DESCRIBED THE WORLD'S MYTHS

In 1949 Joseph Campbell published *The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, comparing myths from around the world and arguing they share one pattern, the “monomyth” — a term he borrowed from James Joyce. A hero leaves the ordinary world, is tested, is transformed, comes home changed. It was comparative mythology, not a writing manual.

A STUDIO MEMO MADE IT A FORMULA

George Lucas credited Campbell for *Star Wars* and called him “my Yoda.” Then, in the mid-1980s, Christopher Vogler, a story analyst at Disney, wrote a seven-page memo called “A Practical Guide to The Hero with a Thousand Faces,” turning Campbell into twelve steps for screenwriters. It circulated through Hollywood, and in 1992 he expanded it into the book *The Writer's Journey*. A description of ancient myths became a checklist for development meetings.

THE RULE IT CREATED

The checklist brought an assumption with it: a main character must change. Want something, learn what they really need, come out different. A story where nobody changes started to look, to a development executive, like a story that was not finished.

THREE WAYS A CHARACTER CAN MOVE

ONE

THE RISE

The character overcomes a flaw and ends up better. The classic hero's journey.

Star Wars · The Lion King · Moana

TWO

THE FALL

The same steps run downhill. The character gets what they want and loses who they were.

The Godfather · There Will Be Blood · Breaking Bad

THREE

THE FLAT LINE

The character barely changes. Instead the story reveals them, or they change the people around them.

Lost in Translation · Paddington · Paterson

The third one is the hardest to sell and the easiest to love.

ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

Writers separate a character's **want**, what they chase, from their **need**, what would actually fix them. Michael wants to protect his father. What he needs is to stay out. Watch which one each film cares about.

WHY THESE FILMS

Part Three starts with the person at the centre. A father made the most famous fall in film. His daughter made a film about two people who refuse to transform, and won an Oscar for it.

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S FILM FORUM

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from the AFI Catalog, the Academy's awards database, the Museum of the Moving Image, American Cinematographer, Variety and MovieMaker. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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